time. Full of deep valleys and dense jungles, the region was inhabited by a fierce and primitive tribe known as the Tagins. In 1953, reports had been received that a number of foreigners—both Chinese and Tibetan—had infiltrated the area and had distributed presents among the villagers while exhorting them to resist Indian administrative control.

A strong column consisting of twenty-three men from 7 Assam Rifles under the command of Major R. D. Singh from the Dogra Regiment was sent into the area to investigate the report. This column was accompanied by 150 personnel including the area superintendent and a political jemadar. On the afternoon of 22 October 1953, the party reached Achingmori where it set up camp. Sentries were posted, but as was usual, a large number of Tagins had collected around the camp, seeking salt and presents that the political officers usually brought with them. The members of the party were unconcernedly going about their various chores when the Tagins, given a signal, attacked the sentries with their dhas and hacked to death most of the members of the column, including Major R. D. Singh and almost all the riflemen. The few who survived the carnage were taken hostage.

It took a major operation in December 1953 involving the army and the air force to bring the culprits to book. Though primarily conducted by the Assam Rifles, this was the first time in independent India that the Indian armed forces stepped into NEFA operationally—three companies of the Parachute Regiment, the mortar platoon of 1 Garhwal Rifles, twenty-two signalmen, six Harwards from No. 17 Squadron, six Spitfires from No. 14 Squadron and five Dakotas from No. 5 Squadron.

PANCHSHEEL AND ITS AFTERMATH

Not only did Nehru continue to ignore the hardliners, but by the end of 1953 India had even initiated fresh talks on the Tibet issue with China. During the six months of discussions, the Indian ambassador to China, P. Nedyam Raghavan, failed to realize that while the Chinese wanted to resolve the Tibet problem quickly, their strategy with regard to the Sino-Indian border was quite the opposite. A memo accessed from the Chinese Foreign Ministry dated 21 October 1953 clearly states that the Tawang issue needed to be kept ‘alive’ and that it would be beneficial for the Chinese ‘to drag on these issues for the time being’.

General Maharaj Kumar Shri Rajendrasinhji had taken over as the Commander-in-Chief from General Cariappa in January 1953. A committee